

Introducing Government and Politics

What is Government?

1. A government is the system to govern a state or community.
2. The institution or institutions that possess the basic authority and can legitimately use force to rule over a society.
3. The body of persons that constitutes the governing authority of a political unit or organization
4. Government the system or form by which a community or other political unit is governed.
5. Government, the political system by which a country or community is administered and regulated.
6. A government is the system or group of people governing an organized community, generally a state.
7. Government is the institution through which a society makes and enforces its public policies.
8. A government is a system of social control under which right to make laws, and the right to enforce them, is vested in a particular group in society.
9. The institutions and processes through which public policies are made for society.
10. A set of individuals with both the power and authority to control and direct the affairs of a group, society or country.
11. Government is an organization or administration in which a group of people work together as a unit (elected by people of the country) to run the nation as indicated by the defined law.
12. Government is a group of people who rule or run the institution of a country. In other words, it may be said that a government is the body of representatives that governs and controls the state at a given time. Government is the medium through which the power of the state is employed.

What is Politics?

1. "Man is by nature a political animal."
2. Politics is the authoritative allocation of resources.
3. Politics is that who gets what, when and how.
4. Politics is the sign of who gets what, when, and why.
5. Politics is the study of how people get what they want.
6. The meaning of the term Politics has been confined to business and activity which has to with the actual conduct of the affairs of the state.
8. The process by which we select our governmental leaders and what policies these leaders produce. Politics produces authoritative decisions about public issues.

Political Science: Definition, Nature and Scope

Definition of Political Science

Traditional Definition:

These early definitions of political science dealt generally with state and government.

1. Paul Janet: "Political Science is that part of social science which treats the foundations of the State and the principles of government." (Kapur, A.C. Principles of Political Science, S. Chand & Company Ltd., New Delhi, 2006, p.17)

2. Dr. Garner: "Political Science begins and ends with the state." (Agarwal, R. C. :Political Theory-Principles of Political Science, S.Chand& Company Ltd., New Delhi, 2007, p.3)

3. Sir John Seeley: "Political Science investigates the phenomena of Government as Political Economy deals with Wealth, Biology with life, Algebra with numbers and Geometry with space and magnitude." (Agarwal, R.C.: Political Theory-Principles of Political Science, S. Chand & Company Ltd., New Delhi, 2007, p.3).

4. Stephen Leacock: "Political Science deals with the Government" (Agarwal, R. C.: Political Theory-Principles of Political Science, S. Chand & Company Ltd., New Delhi, 2007, p.3).

Modern Definition:

In the beginning of the 20th century there developed a new way of looking at political science. This new approach is known as behavioral approach. The main thrust of the new view is the treatment of politics as an activity and a process.

1. Harold Laswell: "Politics is the study of influence and the influential" or "the study of the shaping and sharing of power."

2. David Easton: "Politics is the authoritative allocation of values."

3. Catlin: "Political Science is the study of the act of human and social control".

4. Andrew Heywood: "Politics can be defined as an activity through which people make, preserve and amend the general rules under which they live." (Source: Agarwal, R. C.: Political Theory- Principles of Political Science, S. Chand & Company Ltd., New Delhi, 2007)

Nature of Political Science

Political Science is a part of social sciences and therefore is different from that of physical sciences like physics and chemistry.

So the question which concerns the nature of the subject is whether Political Science is a Science or an Art and how the nature of the discipline has undergone changes in the 20th century.

Changing dynamics of the meaning and nature of Political Science

A) After the World War II, the meaning and nature of political science have undergone a sea change.

B) Now political science is closely related to all aspects of social relations, rather than an activity centered on the institutions of government.

C) So the aims and objectives of political science have changed due to factors such as the rise of the power theory and behaviouralism. New understanding of Political Science

D) Political Science has ceased to be merely the science of state-craft.

E) Political Science is concerned with all facets of power relations and human behavior having political implications in the society.

F) Politics is portrayed as a process of conflict resolution, in which rival views or competing interests are reconciled for the benefit of all. The new meaning of Political Science includes the dynamics of power and struggle at various levels—local, regional, national and international.

G) So the aims and objectives of Political Science have changed due to factors such as the rise of the power theory and behaviouralism.

Scope of Political Science

Political science as a discipline deals with various aspects like:

A) Study of state and government- it deals with the nature and formation of the State and tries to understand various forms and functions of the government.

B) Study of associations and institutions- in organized way the fundamental problems of political science include, first, an investigation of the origin and the nature of the state, second an inquiry into the nature, history and forms of political institutions and third, deduction, therefore, so far as possible, of laws of political growth and development.

C) Study of national and international problems- modern demands of defense of territory, representative government and national unity have made political science not only the science of political independence but that of state sovereignty also.

D) Study of political behavior of man- it may be said that the character of political science in all its parts

is determined by its basic pre-supposition regarding man.

E) Study of the past, present and future of development- political science attempts to explain the meaning and the essential nature of the state and deals with the laws of its progress and development within itself and in relation to international organizations and other states.

F) Study of the concepts of power, authority & influence- with the behavioral revolution the central topic for study has become the study of power. Consequently the scope has widened to include new aspects like political socialization, political culture, political development and informal structures like interest and pressure groups.

Political Ideology

• What is political ideology?

- One's basic beliefs about power, political values, and the role of government
- Grows out of economical, educational, and social conditions and experiences

• 4 Main Ideologies in America Today

- Liberalism
- Conservatism
- Socialism
- Libertarianism

} Moderate (Middle of the Road)

An *ideology* is a set of opinions or beliefs of a group or an individual. Very often *ideology* refers to a set of political beliefs or a set of ideas that characterize a particular culture.

What is political ideology?

A definition of 'ideology' must be neutral. It must reject the notion that ideologies are 'good' or 'bad', true or false, or liberating or oppressive.

The modern, social scientific meaning of the term, sees ideology as an action-orientated belief system, an interrelated set of ideas that in some way guides or inspires political action

Characteristics of Ideology

- Ideologies have their levels end in -ism
- Ideologies provide an explanation for problems but confronts modern societies by providing futuristic visions.
- Ideology is action- oriented.
- Ideologies mobilize a large number of people.

List of political ideologies

Political Ideology ¹	Core Frames ²	Ideological Markers ³
Anarchism	anti-clericalism, anti-statism, economic freedom, utopianism	chaos and disorder, direct action, free, autonomous human beings, natural social order, no economic control, no management, no political authority, no regulation, perfect society, radicalism, respect, social solidarity, stateless society, unnecessary state, unregulated market economy, voluntary agreement
Conservatism	authority, hierarchy, human imperfection, organic society, tradition, property	common morality, faith in God, family traditions, family values, functionalism, guidance for social actions, hierarchical society, individual tendency for corruption, national identity, national loyalty, paternalism, pragmatism, search for security, social gradation, social justice, social obligations, social order, social principles, state authority, strong criminal regime, strong government, traditional mores, traditional practices
Ecologism	conservation, ecology, environmental ethics, holism, sustainability	air pollution, biodiversity, climate change, ecological balance, ecosystems, environmental organisations, environmental protection, global warming, natural disasters caused by human interventions, natural resources, non-human life, preservation, renewable sources, restoration and/or improvement of the natural environment, social balance and harmony, soil and water pollution, sustainable growth, waste management
Fascism	anti-rationalism, elitism, leadership, state socialism, struggle, ultra-nationalism	anti-capitalist, anti-communist, anti-conservative, anti-immigration, anti-intellectualism, anti-liberal, authority, commitment and faith, competition natural for human progress, corporatism, duty, heroism, honour, patriarchy, power, progress, self-sacrifice, state worship
Feminism	equality and difference,	abortion, anti sex oppression, anti-subordination, body autonomy and integrity, child sexual abuse, deconstructing gender identities,